

Q Would it be correct to assume that most of the customers are going to be high-end premium customers rather than small players?

A. We have a mix of hosting customers. The business of the majority of our international customers is high-volume with the per-customer revenue generation being low, whereas in India, we are seeing mostly high-end premium customers getting on board and opting for our services.

Q Has any startup grown with you?

A. Yes, there are many startups that are hosted with us and some of them have grown 20 times in the last three years. Due to our terms of non-disclosure, I would be unable to identify them publicly.

Q Do you have any special programmes for startups?

A. Our unique and innovative pay-per-consume billing model itself is a special offering for startups. While cloud providers bill the customers for the allocation, eNlight cloud bills the customers for actual usage of resources. This is something similar to the electricity billing model that we are accustomed to at our homes. We have also assisted startups to have compute as a utility on a prepaid billing model such as mobile SIM cards. This billing model helps the clients save more than 30 per cent compared to the pay-per-use model.

Q There is a lot of talk about the IoT. What is your personal take on this? Do you see a huge amount of business coming to cloud companies also because of IoT?

A. The IoT is the future and it is not very far away. We will see another data explosion from the point we are at today. Every instrument comes with multiple sensors attached to it today, be it a small watch, a pen or a mobile — all the way up to aircrafts and rockets. Companies are coming up with digital products, but where is all this data going to get stored? These companies are not coming up with their own data centres. With the world moving towards a 'machines controlling machines' era, the business of the cloud is going to grow multifold in the next three to five years and IoT is going to be a clear driver for this. IoT feeds into another revenue stream that goes by the name of Big Data analytics. Finally, the data has to be transformed into information that is meaningful and can be used.

Q What does open source mean to ESDS?

A. ESDS is a strong believer in open source technologies. We believe that, very soon, proprietary systems will be a thing from the past and those who do not embrace open systems will follow suit. Our products are completely built on open source platforms. We also have a very unique way of demonstrating a cross-platform concept, under which

customers can do a PoC (proof of concept) of their proprietary systems on open platforms in our data centre.

Q Where do you see revenue coming from -- customers seeking an open source stack or those with a preference for the proprietary stack.

A. We are seeing organisations taking the initiative of moving to the open source stack, and the numbers are increasing each day. Customers are embracing open source technologies for non-critical loads for sure, while trying out PoC for their critical systems. Currently, the revenue would be around 50-50 but, going forward, the trend is definitely skewing towards open source stacks.

Q You have mentioned that you are seeing growth coming from the telecom sector, existing customers shifting to the cloud

and from e-commerce. As I understand, these are the top three sources. Will this trend to continue or do you see any new sectors emerging?

A. Telecom players are always the trend setters in this industry. Fortunately, e-commerce companies were mostly startups, so they could directly move to the cloud, while the existing customers who have invested heavily in their infrastructure are already starting to move their workloads to the cloud, as their infrastructure is approaching the end of its life. Everyone is moving from the capex to the opex model, and many organisations have already realised the pain of having an in-house data centre. With the Digital India initiative, the government will contribute to the business at large, and with our vertical auto scaling technology, industries in oil and gas, or aviation, or those that use legacy systems, will be able to take advantage of the cloud, thereby contributing to growth.

Q So what is the biggest challenge for your business?

A. The biggest challenge in the data centre industry is the huge capital required to build and maintain the data centre. The investments needed to boost this industry in India are still not happening at the rate they should be. There is also the challenge of skilled manpower, since it is a different kind of industry with varied technology and the skills needed are not readily available in abundance. Besides, the cost of power and bandwidth is still very high compared to developed nations, thereby increasing the operating expenses.

Q Lastly, what are the top three or five technology trends that you would want a typical CIO or CTO to keep in mind when it comes to the cloud, or even migrating to it?

A. The hybrid cloud, the Internet of Things, Dockers and more initiatives around Devops, interoperability and security should be what CIOs or CTOs keep their eyes on. 